PICK THESE UP
Shades of India's new showroom on MG Road, Delhi showcases high-performance and high-design textiles







I have always been interested in textiles that reveal themselves through touch. The way a weave feels, the way a surface catches light, the slight variation within a yarn—these are the details that give a fabric its character. Performance should not take those qualities away.

The most successful materials, for me, are those where utility becomes almost invisible. You see a beautiful textile, feel its texture and only later realise how well it responds to everyday use. A fabric should belong to the space first and perform quietly in the background.

At Shades of India, when we design textiles for homes, we think about how people actually live with them. A curtain is not simply something that covers a window. It filters light throughout the day and changes the atmosphere of a room. Upholstery has to withstand repeated use while remaining comfortable to touch. A cushion is handled, moved, leaned against and eventually becomes part of the rhythm of a home.

These everyday interactions are what I find most interesting. A textile has to respond to them without losing its visual and tactile character.

This is where material selection becomes critical. Fibre, construction, weave and finish all influence how a textile behaves. The more closely you work with materials, the more you understand that performance is not one quality. It comes from a combination of many small decisions.

I don't believe a home should feel precious in the sense that everything has to be protected from use. Some of the most beautiful spaces are those where textiles are allowed to be touched, moved, folded and lived with. There is an ease in knowing that a fabric can accommodate everyday life without becoming difficult to live with. This feels particularly relevant to contemporary Indian homes, where spaces are often social and constantly evolving. We gather, entertain, eat, work and move between rooms. Our textiles need to accommodate that richness of living.

For me, the real opportunity with high-performance textiles is to remove friction from everyday living. A fabric that looks beautiful but requires constant care can become difficult to live with. Equally, a highly practical fabric that feels synthetic or lacks character can make a space feel impersonal.

The ideal lies somewhere between the two: a textile with depth and softness, but also resilience. Something that feels considered but not delicate. Something that allows you to live fully in a space without constantly thinking about how to protect it. Perhaps that is where contemporary luxury is moving towards materials that understand the realities of how we live, while allowing beauty to remain effortless.

The best-performing textile, in the end, may be the one you never think about as a performance fabric. You simply know that it feels good, looks right, and works beautifully in the life around it.